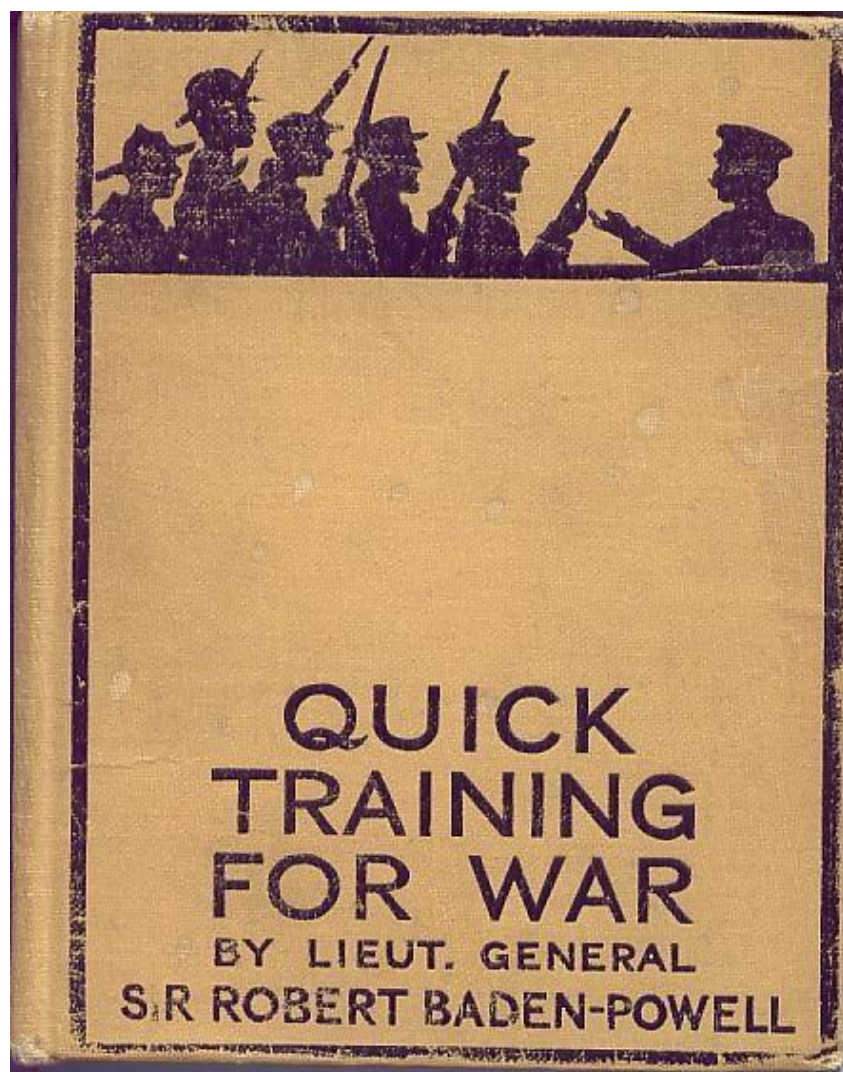




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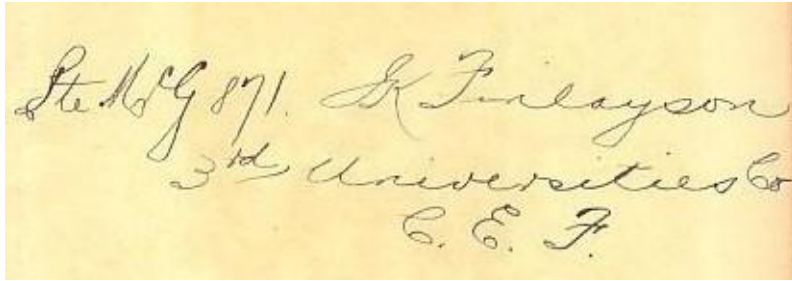


Editor's Note:

The reader is reminded that these texts have been written a long time ago. Consequently, they may use some terms or use expressions which were current at the time, regardless of what we may think of them at the beginning of the 21st century. For reasons of historical accuracy they have been preserved in their original form.

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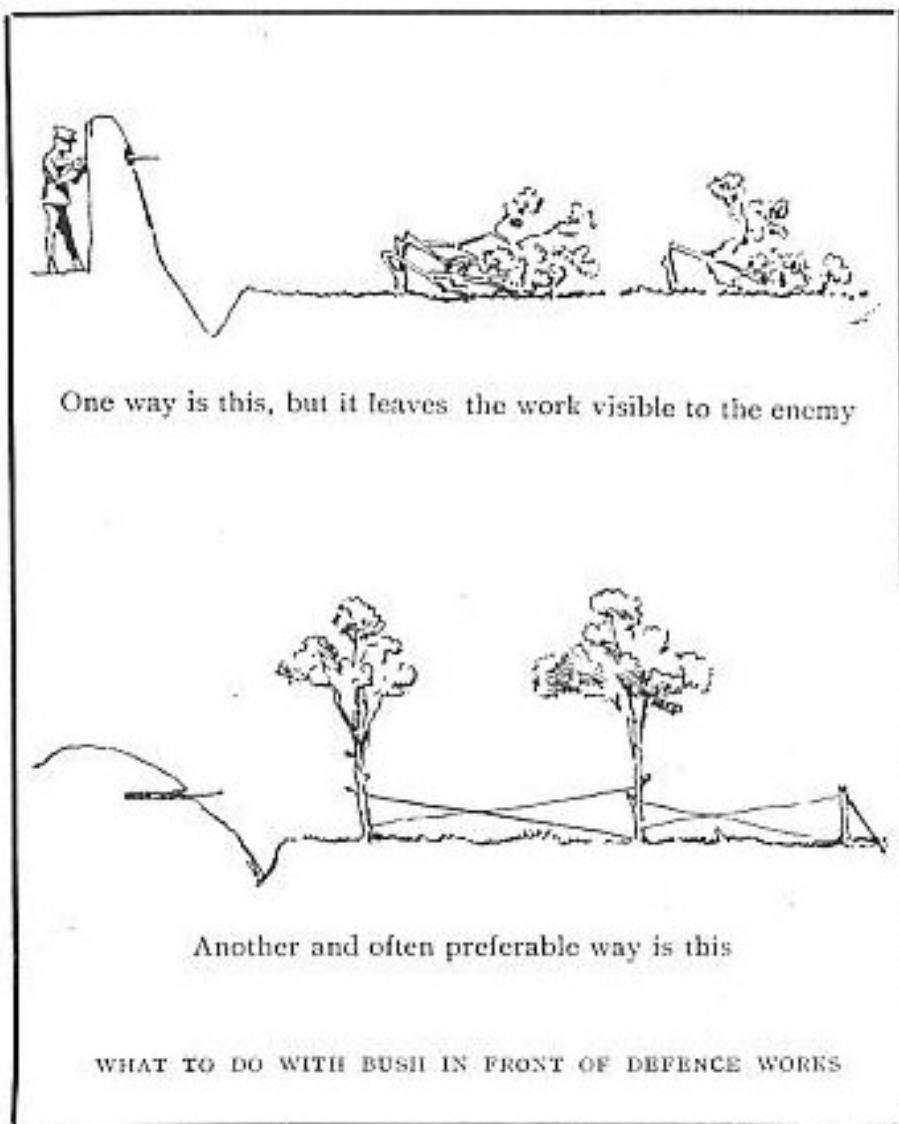
Inscription from flyleaf of the original from which this e-edition is taken.
"C.E.F." stands for Canadian Expeditionary Force

John Kennedy Finlayson was born in Scotland in 1885 and immigrated to Saskatoon, Saskatchewan, where he worked as an accountant. He enlisted as a Private in the 3rd. Universities Co. in 1915, later transferred to Princess Patricia's Canadian Light Infantry, and was wounded in Belgium in June, 1916. He was eventually promoted to Lieutenant and survived the war.

The transcription of *Quick Training for War* is dedicated to the memory of the young men who volunteered for the Canadian Expeditionary Force during the Great War.

QUICK TRAINING FOR WAR
BY SIR ROBT. BADEN-POWELL

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· QUICK ·
· TRAINING ·
FOR WAR

A FEW PRACTICAL SUGGESTIONS
ILLUSTRATED BY DIAGRAMS
BY LIEUT.-GEN.
SIR ROBERT BADEN-POWELL, K.C.B.

DEDICATED TO THE YOUNG OFFICERS
AND MEN WHO HAVE COME FORWARD
IN THEIR COUNTRY'S DEFENCE

TORONTO: BELL & COCKBURN
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FOREWORD

PLEASE do not think that this little book is intended as a substitute, in the form of “Potted Tactics” for the excellent training manuals issued by the War Office — because it is not.

The principles contained in these books require to be fully mastered by every officer and N.C.O. who wants to train his men and to gain their confidence, and therefore their obedience, on service.

But the present crisis demands a quicker development of some sort of efficiency for the field than is laid down in those books, and therefore I have attempted to give in the following pages a few suggestions from practical experience to this end, and towards developing that *spirit* which is described in those manuals as the essential part of military training.

Since the men are as keen to learn as the officers are to teach I should be glad if these hints may be found helpful, not only to the officers and N.C.O.’s in training, but also to the men in learning their work as defenders of their country.

ROBERT BADEN-POWELL.

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QUICK TRAINING FOR WAR

I

THE MAKING OF AN ARMY

THESE was an argument a short time back as to how long it takes to make an efficient soldier out of the average recruit material, and a patriotic newspaper proved by experiment, what many of us already knew, that it was quite feasible to turn out the finished article in six months under favourable circumstances.

But it may be remembered that immediately before the South African campaign we had to take such material as we could find and turn it out efficient for the field in something nearer six weeks than six months. Men whom we enlisted in August were fighting, and fighting well, in October. This was not brought about by teaching them the goose-step, but rather by going straight to the point desired and teaching them to fight in the field. It is comparatively easy to turn out soldiers, if, by soldiers, you mean lads who can dress smartly and march past accurately and well; but these are not necessarily effective for the work of fighting battles against a fighting enemy. Drill is not everything. If it were the Germans would not lose the smallest combat, nor would the Boers, entirely undrilled as they were, have been able to put up such a good fight as they did for two years in the South African campaign.

THE RAW MATERIAL

One day in Hyde Park recently I watch for some time the young officers training their men for the war before us. Memories of my own subalternhood came vividly back to me. I knew their thoughts and I should like to help them. I saw myself back again with my squad of young soldiers, my pocket bulging with the over-sized drill-book of which I had endeavoured to assimilate a portion by heart, and was then trying to give out to the men. I cannot say I was highly interested in the job — nor were my men. I was probably thinking how my overalls fitted and how soon I might dismiss for breakfast, while I gave periodical parrot-like utterances of extracts from the book.

If only someone who knew could have given me an idea of the inner meaning and the possibilities which underlay the training, what a difference it would have made. How those long, dreary hours of dull routine would have shortened themselves, both theoretically and materially, for myself and my men. It was not until years later that light dawned upon me. I had thought that the letter of the book was the sure fetish to success in war. I never read the meaning which lay between the lines.

THE INNER MEANING OF DRILL

As regards squad-drill the under-meaning of it is that, while exercising your squad, you should get to know, not merely the name, but the character and the alertness of mind and capabilities of each one of your men. In the meantime each one of these, unconsciously it may be, is also sizing you up. His life is possibly going to be in your hands. When that time comes he is going to behave towards you as he knows you, and you ought to be inculcating that confidence in you which will bind your men to stick to you in a tight place.

I remember an officer who was a bit of a martinet, who, by his cursing and punishing the men, had roused amongst them a thorough hatred for himself; but he was plucky, there was no doubt whatever of that. One morning when ordered on an expedition with his force, he formed the men up and said, "I know you hate me, and you mean to shoot me in the back at the first opportunity. All I advise you is not to do so just yet. We have got a rough time before us to-day, and it wants a bold push. If you stick to me I'll take you through. You can shoot me as much as you like *afterwards*." Needless to say the enterprise succeeded and he was never shot.

MUTUAL SIZING UP

The sizing up of your men at squad or any other drill requires a close observation and quick eye. In my subaltern days I was lucky enough to make a success of my very first parade, the day after I joined, and in this wise. My troop was ordered to parade in double rank, and I was given by my captain the simple task of walking round to inspect the men and to see that each of them was wearing a cholera belt. Shirts were thrown open and I walked down the front rank, finding each man dressed as he should be. As I turned at the end to come up the rear rank with my eyes downcast from sheer shyness at commanding a parade, I just caught with the tail of my eye a movement at the opposite end of the troop, as a man stepped from the rear rank into the front rank which I had just examined.

I only knew the name of one man in the troop at that time, because he had been detailed to bring me my horse, and this happened to be the man who stepped across. I took no notice of the move, as I had to debate in my mind whether or not it might be a bit of orthodox drill that, when the officer arrived at the rear rank, one of its number should step into the front rank. As I passed along the rear rank examining their belts I pondered the matter over, and came to the conclusion that I would risk matters and call this man out.

On arriving at the front again, I called, "Private Ramsbotham, step to the front. Have you got your cholera belt on?" There was a blushing, confused reply of, "No, sir." I did not punish him, as I was not clear what powers of punishment I had; but I said, with much fear and great gruffness, "Take care you don't allow it to occur again," and dismissed him. But the punishment which he afterwards got from his own comrades in the way of jeers at being caught out by a fresh-joined subaltern was far heavier for him to bear than any that I could have inflicted.

OFFICERS AND MEN

A subaltern or non-commissioned officer, if he desire to succeed in getting the best out of squad drill, must practise the closest observation on every one of his men.

I have only just received the Defence Force report from one of our Oversea Dominions, which contains these suggestive paragraphs:

"Squadron or company training brings commanders into touch with their subordinates very much to the advantage of both. Here officers and non-commissioned officers learn to make practical application of the knowledge they have acquired at their classes, and become the recognised instructors of men already prepared by their work as recruits to profit by such tuition. Here, by degrees, the captain, subaltern, sergeant, or corporal becomes, each in his own sphere, the recognised leader, guide, enlightener of his men. Here, in short, the commander obtains that ascendancy over the minds of the men which engenders discipline.

"But what, after all, is this modern discipline? The men join the ranks full of good will and anxiety to acquit themselves well in the performance of a duty demanded of them by the State. The officers and non-commissioned officers are at least equally

anxious to show them how best to achieve this same national purpose. Gradually mutual esteem, and very probably affection, are evolved out of the relationship of eager master and willing pupil. The two are knit together more and more closely by the generous warmth of feeling consequent on working for a purely unselfish object. There is no money in it. If the commander sweats the subordinate, that sort of sweat does not go to make the commander fat. On the contrary, he is bound in honour to sweat himself at least twice as much as his men. The rank and file (the workers) recognise these truths instinctively and very quickly. They learn to trust their instructors, and the instructors learn to trust them. When this point has been reached the unit will bear the strain of discomfort and danger without loss either of cohesion or courage.”

THE NECESSITY FOR DRILL

In raiding the force now needed for the defence of the country, we have, if I may judge from appearances, the best possible material. The men are eager and willing to learn. As a friend has expressed it, “there is in these men’s eyes the look that is sometimes seen in that of a dog when he seems to say, ‘What is it that master wants? If only I knew!’” And indeed the men seem eager to learn; but it is only natural that the tedium of the mere goose-step will very soon pall upon them and dam their ardour. They have enlisted to fight for their country. My advice is, do not let them cool down; strike while the iron is hot, give them food of interesting work and not the dry bones of mechanical drill. Drill has its use for moving bodies of men rapidly and in good order for manœuvring purposes, but it is not the end-all of their training. The spirit which is inculcated into the men is of far greater importance.

Mere drill can only manufacture soldiers very slowly, and, where there is need for speeding-up the training, a certain amount of imagination and a great deal of go have to be employed by the officers carrying out the instruction, as well as by the men themselves in receiving it.

We have an illustration of this brought very vividly before us to-day in the respective fighting qualities of the Belgian and German soldier and their fitness to win. No one will deny that in drill and drill-book lore the German is far ahead of the Belgian; yet the *élan* and intelligence of the latter render him an equally good soldier. The newspapers are full of authenticated instances of small parties of Belgian or British soldiers consisting of a dozen or twenty men defeating much larger bodies of the enemy, and always because of individual initiative and the right spirit which constitutes fitness to win.

SUCCESS IN WAR

The *Training Regulations* for the British army lay down as a first item that “The sole object of military training is to prepare our forces for war, success in battle being constantly held in view as the ultimate aim.”

The first point laid down in the Field Service Regulations is:

“Success in war depends more on the moral than on the physical qualities. Skill cannot compensate for want of courage, energy, and determination: but even high moral quality may not avail without careful preparation and skilful direction. The development of moral qualities is therefore first of the objects to be attained; the next are organisation and discipline which enable those qualities to be controlled and used when required.”

There then are the foundations, or should be, of the training of the soldier. Were they always borne in mind by instructors of recruits the training would be more interesting, more effective, and more rapid; but it is almost traditional with us that the whole process of training should begin with the physical side, the drilling and the setting up, and, excellent though the manuals are and the principles which they

express, still it is difficult for the young officer or non-commissioned officer to see from them exactly where he can bring in the moral attributes demanded, when training his squad in the accepted forms of barrack-square drill. Perhaps some of these hints may be a help to him.

THE GERMAN EMPEROR ON OUR ALPHABETICAL METHODS

I once had the interesting experience of having a talk with the present German Emperor regarding the relative value of the different arms in the field; and His Majesty said, "You will observe that I put the infantry in the front line on parade, while the cavalry, artillery, engineers, and train come in the second line. The infantry take the place of honour, since, by virtue of their armament and action, it is the infantry who win the battles; the remainder are their servants." I cordially acquiesced in the Emperor's statement; but then he turned on me and put me a "poser," "Why, then, do you in England put the artillery in the place of honour on the right of the line, the cavalry next, and then in the engineers, and lastly the infantry?" I was rather at a loss for an answer, and blurted out the first idea that came into my head. I said, "I suppose it is that we place them in alphabetical order," and this answer greatly pleased His Majesty, if one could judge by the chuckling which lasted for some time afterwards.

II

THE FOUR C'S OF SOLDIERING

I. COURAGE

WELL, if we do these things in alphabetical order, let us be consistent. There are other things besides drill which go to make the soldier. There are four very important attributes, so important that I need not touch on any others in these pages, and these all begin with the letter "C." Therefore in our training they should surely come before Drill, which commences with a "D." They are:

Courage, Common-sense, Cunning, Cheerfulness.

THE DEVELOPMENT OF COURAGE

Some men are born brave, others require to have it thrust upon them. But in the large majority of cases it is a quality which can be cultivated. Without it a soldier is practically useless in the field. I do not know that drill goes very far towards developing it. I believe that for a man gifted with ordinary bodily development and health it is largely the outcome of confidence in himself, in his leaders, and in his comrades. It may be remembered of General Grant that in the American War of North and South he admitted that in his first action he found himself in a desperate funk, and was dodging and creeping along behind cover in order to avoid the enemy's aim, when he noticed that those who were out against him were doing precisely the same thing, and soon he realised that they were just as much afraid of him as he was of them. Buoyed with a new hope, he rushed at them, and they at once incontinently took to their heels. He never felt afraid again, but always pushed forward in the sure confidence that the bolder his advance the more rapid would be the retirement of the enemy. But this same confidence in self can only come where the man knows that he is at least equal to if not better than the enemy opposed to him.

CONFIDENCE IN YOURSELF

If your man is an infantryman he must feel confident that he is able to march long distances without feeling the weight of his kit or suffering in his feet. He must know that he is expert with his rifle, and that not only is he a good shot at the target on the range, but that he is able to hit moving objects in the field, and, above all, is an accurate judge of distance.

These, then, must be some of the first objects of your training.

MARKSMANSHIP

In South Africa we always had the idea that the Boers were first-class marksmen. I have on many occasions fired matches with them. On the fixed-range at known distances they could not hold their own against soldier-marksmen, but in the field when firing at moving targets and having to estimate for himself the distance and the allowance to make for the speed of the target, the ordinary soldier could not hold a candle to the Boers. It was that power of estimating distance in an atmosphere to which he was accustomed which gave the Boer his superiority.

The German Army instructions for judging distance are given as follows:

At 50 yards the mouth and eyes of the enemy can clearly be seen.

At 100 yards the eyes appear as dots.

At 200 yards buttons and details of uniform can still be seen.

At 300 yards faces can still be seen.

At 400 yards movement of the legs can be seen.

At 500 yards colour of the uniform can be seen.

JUDGING DISTANCE

These are all very well when you can see your enemy in the field, but so often you can see nothing of him, and consequently have to judge by objects near to which he lies. Then it has to be remembered that these objects look much nearer when the light is bright and shining upon them, or when looking across water or snow, or looking up or down hill. Objects appear further off than they really are when in the shade, across a valley, when the background is of the same colour, when the observer is lying down or kneeling, or when there is a heat haze over the ground.

Judging distance has by practice to be a second habit with a man if he is to be a good shot in the field. In these days it has to include, in addition to its ordinary features, the estimation of heights at which an enemy's aeroplane is flying. The airman is not going to fly low if he sees troops waiting for him. You have got to learn how to hide from him and to ambush hostile aircraft, and not to fire without a good chance of bringing him down, otherwise he will from your firing gain the information he desires as to your whereabouts.

When you are firing at aircraft, don't forget that your bullets or shells have got to come down again after meeting the flyer. Whom are you likely to damage thus?

CONFIDENCE IN YOUR HORSEMANSHIP

Another kind of confidence needed in our soldiers is that of being able to act alone in the darkness at night. With a little practice it is wonderful what a difference it makes to a man's capabilities for useful work.

If our soldier belongs to the mounted branch he can have little confidence in himself if he is not a good horseman and mounted on a good horse. By horseman I do not mean that he is able to ride and handle his horse under the many situations required of a cavalry soldier, but that he is also an efficient horse-master, and knows how to keep his horse fit for action and capable of a life-ride at any moment. These are matters which come only by training and practice, and which no amount of drill will inculcate.

CONFIDENCE IN YOUR PALS

Yet another step to confidence is that of knowing that his comrades around him are all equally good men; that they understand their job, and will play the game and stick it out with him to the end. This they can only do by knowing what the game is, having an intelligent interest in it, and having a certain amount of sense of self-sacrifice and helpfulness to each other in getting the work done. The spirit in the men is of greater value than any other quality that can be produced. It is, in fact, another "C", viz., that of character which goes to make them efficient for war. Now this character and spirit are about the last things that drill will put into a man, yet of all things they are the most valuable.

CONFIDENCE IN YOUR LEADERS

The last form of confidence, which is possibly the most important of them all for giving a man courage in the field, is confidence in his leader. To inspire confidence in his men the leader must as a matter of course have absolute confidence in himself. He can only have this if he knows the whole of his work from A to Z, and if he feels that he is ready to meet any occasion or any tricks that Fate may try to play on him in the strenuous work of active service. His men are observing him all the time, they are

QUICK TRAINING FOR WAR

quick to read his character, because instinctively they feel that their lives are largely in his hands. They are quick to detect any nervousness or hesitation in his action and to adopt it as their own, but they are even more quick, fortunately for us, to catch on to any dash and bravery and self-confidence which he may display. If he possesses that electric touch of leadership which comes from the possession of the four “C’s” of soldiering, they will brace their minds and follow him if need be to the gates of hell.

MACHINE-MADE DISCIPLINE

That is the secret of discipline. The so-called military discipline of repression by punishment for any neglect of orders is a soul-destroying machine which strangles true efficiency. The old iron-bound discipline of former days which regulated more brutish minds to the hand of brave and manly, though it may be unintelligent officer, has given place to a higher tone of discipline which comes of a sense of playing the game for one’s side, and of carrying out a difficult or dangerous task from a sense of duty rather than from fear of punishment. This, if it coupled with a genuine belief in the powers of the leader, constitutes the highest and most enthusiastic form of discipline, such as carries men through tight places and wins battles.

Among the many duties laid down for an officer there is one which I have not seen prominently alluded to, and yet it has a very important bearing on the confidence of the men in themselves and in their ability to carry out an arduous campaign, and is therefore an important step towards courage. Those who have not been on active service scarcely realise the change of atmosphere which comes over the men after a few days or weeks of campaigning. The average spectator only sees the men going on service like lions, and is unaware of what lambs they become when worn with marching, “fed up,” as they call it, with hard fare and hardships. Thus the health and fitness of the men is really a matter of extreme importance; and just as the cavalryman should be a good horse-master as well as a good horseman, the commander of troops must be a good man-master as well as a good man-leader in the field.

HEALTH AS A STEP TO COURAGE

“It is just as much part of the soldier’s duty to be healthy as to be a good horseman or a good shot; and it is just as much the duty of the officer to teach him how to be so and to see that he is so as to teach him to ride or to shoot or to be efficient in other ways.” This was a warning which I once had to publish on the subject of sickness. In the South African campaign we had 18,000 men admitted to hospital for wounds, but nearly 400,000 for sickness, though South Africa is not such a very unhealthy country.

The average men do not know how to look after their own personal hygiene in the slightest degree, and officers will do well to impress upon them a few useful hints in the course of their training for war. Drill will not do it.

HOW TO INCULCATE COURAGE

Above all, the officer must include in his scheme of training the teaching of the spirit and moral of soldiering. To the importance of this I have already drawn attention. I will here add a few suggestions towards its development in the men. Whether you are an officer or N.C.O. teaching, or a man learning, courage, practise these points which make you an expert at your work as a fighting-man. You will gain CONFIDENCE in yourself as being at least as good, if not better, than your opponent, whether at

Marching,
Judging distance,
Straight shooting,
Horsemanship,

Scouting,
Stalking,
Night work,
Entrenching,
Skill with bayonet, sword, or lance.

These come by practice and competition more quickly than by drill. General Nogi, the great Japanese leader who displayed in his life and in his death the highest personal courage, said that though timid by nature he had developed this quality by stern self-discipline. When he found a job which caused him apprehension or fear he forced himself to face it, and to repeat it again and again until it no longer had any terrors for him. It is that taking oneself firmly in hand that enables a man to stick it out against the impulse of his knees to give in or to run away in a crisis.

THE GERMAN EMPEROR ON ATTACK

Confidence — the component of courage — comes also from the knowledge that you are not recklessly being sacrificed. I once had a little argument on this point with the German Emperor. He objected to the system in our training which teaches the men to spread out and to take cover in advancing to the attack. He said, “You teach them to be afraid of the bullets before they have even heard one. In the German Army we march the men by rank after rank of their fellows; they cannot fail to carry the position.”

This seems a good theory, but one wants to see the result before one can judge. I imagine it would require an army very strong in reserves and very strong in nerves to carry it though successfully. Our army is small and we cannot supply the weight of numbers required for this form of confidence.

The more intelligent the men the less inclination they have to be ruthlessly sacrificed; and their confidence will be increased as they see their leader has discretion and only takes risks that are reasonable.

SAVING YOUR MEN

One of my best officers showed great aptitude in saving his men when moving under fire. At all times they moved as if being shot at, keeping close to the side of the roads, advancing by short rushes and then lying flat. It thus became a second nature to them to arrive at the spot needed very rapidly, unseen by the enemy and without casualties in their ranks. When it came to charging in with the bayonet they were all there, and did not mind what losses they suffered; and their leader, coupled with his discretion, was the bravest officer I have ever met.

One officer earned the name among his men of “Back-door P——,” because when he led them into a nasty place he generally explained to them that he had an alternative way out of it again, and this gave them no end of confidence.

Discretion therefore need not be confused with funk, unless carried to that excess which stamps it as such.

III

THE FOUR C'S OF SOLDIERING

2. COMMON-SENSE

THE science of strategy and the art of tactics look formidable when contained between the covers of many volumes, and yet they are, after all, nothing more than the application of common-sense to the situation. Strategical moves are those of the chess-player in putting out his pieces where they will stand to do the best advantage for carrying out the game of war when it comes to hand-grips, or tactics; that is, the operations and movements of the troops in actual contact with each other. The books lay down definite principles and examples which serve to guide the leaders when applying their common-sense to the situation before them. No two situations are ever precisely the same, and it is therefore impossible to lay down exact rules that should guide in every case, but a man who carries precedents and principles in his head has no difficulty in applying their teachings in supreme moments of sudden emergency.

For quick training it is, however, essential that a man should understand that the book rules are not necessarily to be followed to the letter, although the principle remains essential. He must apply his own common-sense, and apply it in the simplest possible form if he wishes to be successful.

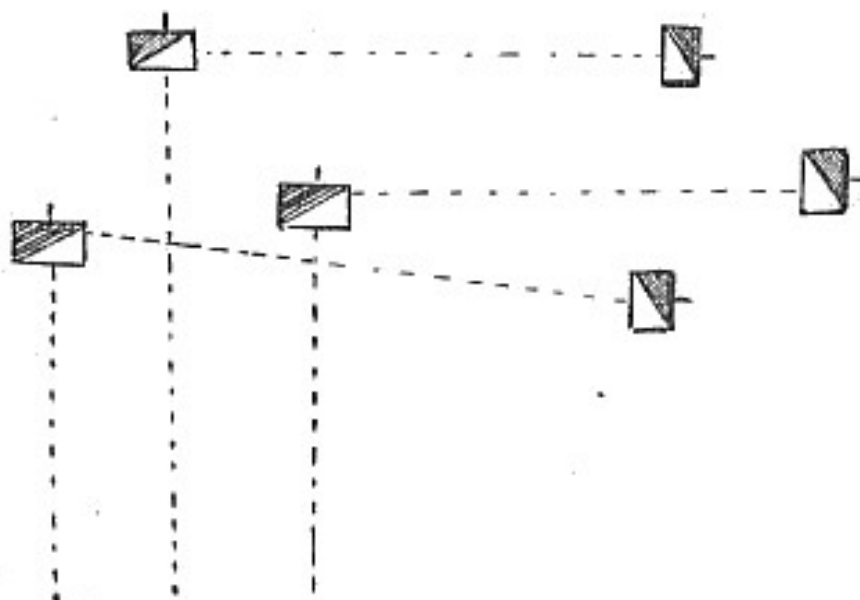
THE TRIANGULAR FORMATION

In the soldier's phrase, "a pound of flesh is worth a ton of bully," and perhaps a little drop of experience by one who has tried it may be worth a bucketful of regulations. I have found it simplest for quick training and have never found it fail in war, the principle of having one's force disposed in triangular fashion. I would not lay this down as a fetish that is always to be adhered to, but I mention it as a useful formation when in doubt. It is a simple proposition and a common-sense one, whether your force is a moving one, or a halted one, or a fixed on, and it applies whether your force is an army corps or a division, a regiment or a patrol. In moving over open country, whether expecting an enemy or not, it is easier to go with one body leading and two others on its exposed and protected rear in support and reserve respectively. I have generally gone against propositions which lay down that such and such a direction is your front, and have always treated every side as my front. Thus, if your moving triangle be attacked from an unexpected quarter it makes no difference to your safety or your dispositions; the body nearest to the enemy becomes the front line and the remaining two become reserve and support respectively.

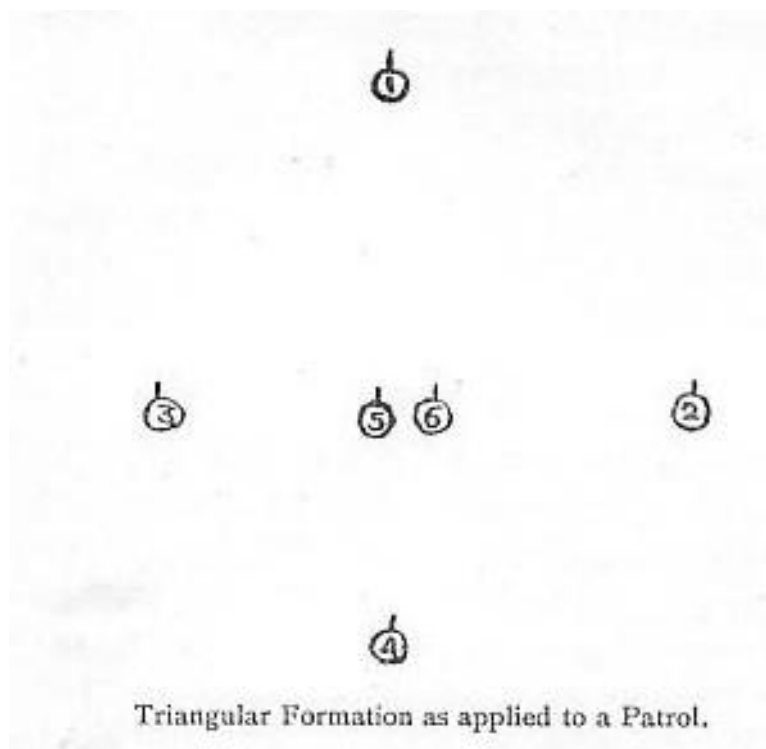
If your force is halted it can often be better halted in three separate parties than in one massed camp. In this way there can be no surprise; if one camp is suddenly assailed the other two have time to get under arms and to protect it.

The Triangular Formation may be applied to a patrol of three men. If there are more, they take position as numbered on the accompanying sketch in order of importance. The commander keeps near the centre to be in touch with all.

Similarly with a fixed force holding entrenchments, if these are disposed in three positions, mutually supporting each other, it is far more effective than if they are all placed in one big work.



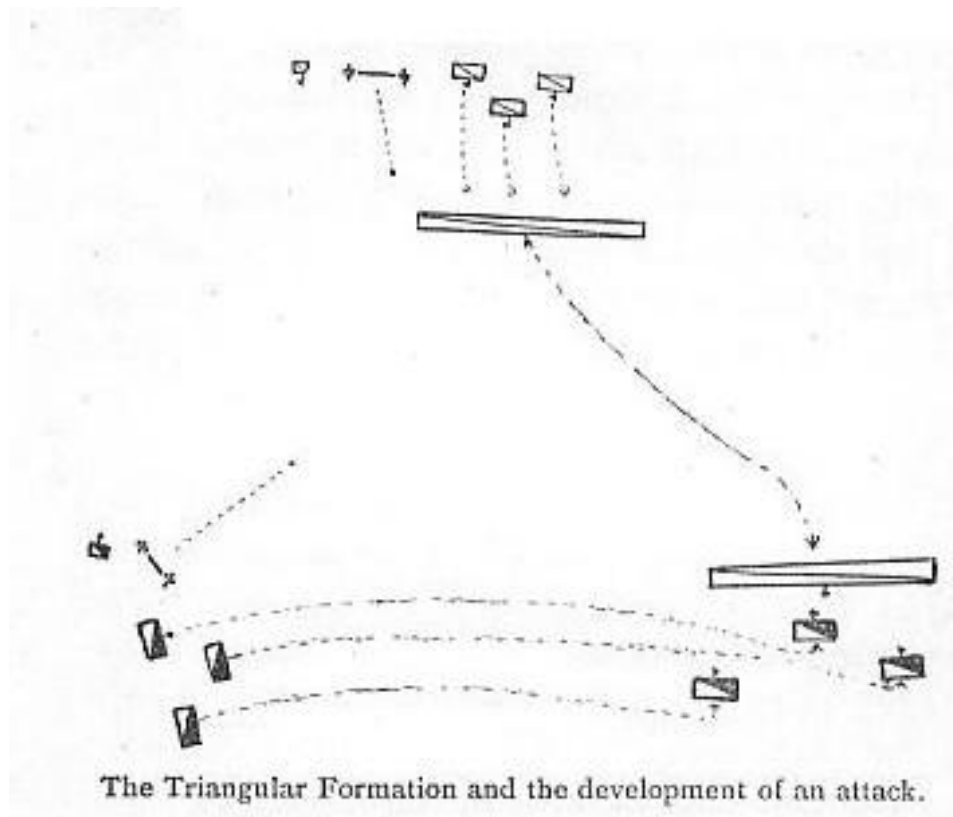
A force marching in Triangle is suddenly required to meet an attack to its right. The body nearest the enemy becomes the front line. The remainder conform and become support and reserve respectively.



A TYPICAL CAVALRY FIGHT

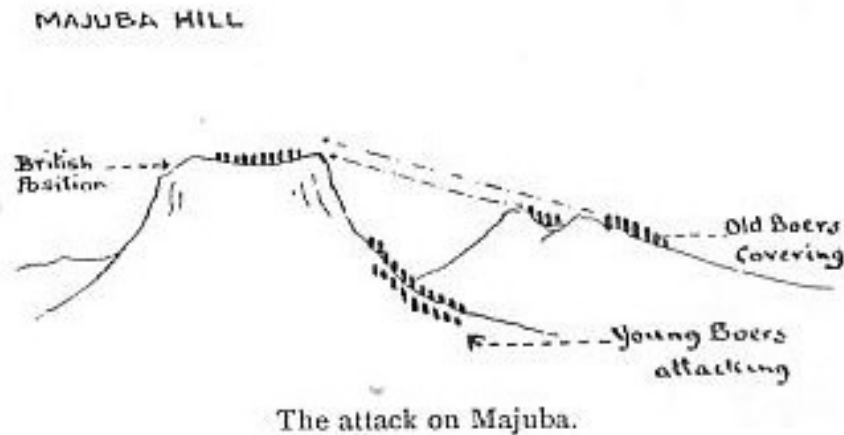
Let me instance a typical cavalry fight as an example of what is meant by common-sense in tactics, and this use of the triangular formation. "The southern division in column of route on the main road learnt that the enemy's division was about two miles distant to its left. Leaving the road, our division formed into preparatory formation with one brigade in front and two in the second line. Our scouts soon signalled that the enemy was in sight approaching the left front. Our guns came into action without delay on the enemy's main body, while our division took ground to the right and thus drew the enemy on to attack it. Then the enemy formed line preparatory to charging, but our division still kept on its course across the front of the enemy in preparatory formation, thus causing him to alter his direction (which it was almost impossible to do in good order when committed to line), and *at the same time drew him across the fire of our guns*. At the last moment our division, wheeling each brigade into line with its left, charged the enemy in double echelon in good order, and was accorded the victory by the umpire."

It will be seen that in carrying out this plan the enemy were not only drawn across the front of our guns, but were also prevented from firing into our division by their own body masking their guns.



THE BOERS AT MAJUBA

How the Boers took Majuba Hill in 1881 has always been a useful lesson to me, and I believe that its lesson is just as good for fighting to-day, whether for a big or a little action. It was again an instance of common-sense tactics, and especially it showed the value of “covering fire.” The British force was on the summit of a high, steep-sided mountain which overlooked everything. The older Boers took position on a neighbouring hilltop about half the height of Majuba and fired at anyone who looked over the crest of the mountain. The younger and more active Boers meantime climbed up the face of the mountain, without being observed or fired upon until they had collected together immediately under the crest, over which no British soldier could show a nose on account of the covering fire from the neighbouring hill. Thus the attackers were able to rush the defenders.



THE IMPORTANCE OF COVERING FIRE

I have seldom seen an attack where covering fire from a separate body told off for the purpose was not of the highest value. I am talking now of small actions, for in the larger ones artillery would naturally do the preparation and covering fire to a great extent. It is, however, surprising how often a commander neglects or probably forgets to make use of it, and finds his task of attacking all the more difficult in consequence; yet it is only a matter of common-sense. Therefore I commend the habitual use of covering-fire at all minor tactical exercises.

THE COMMON-SENSE USE OF CAVALRY

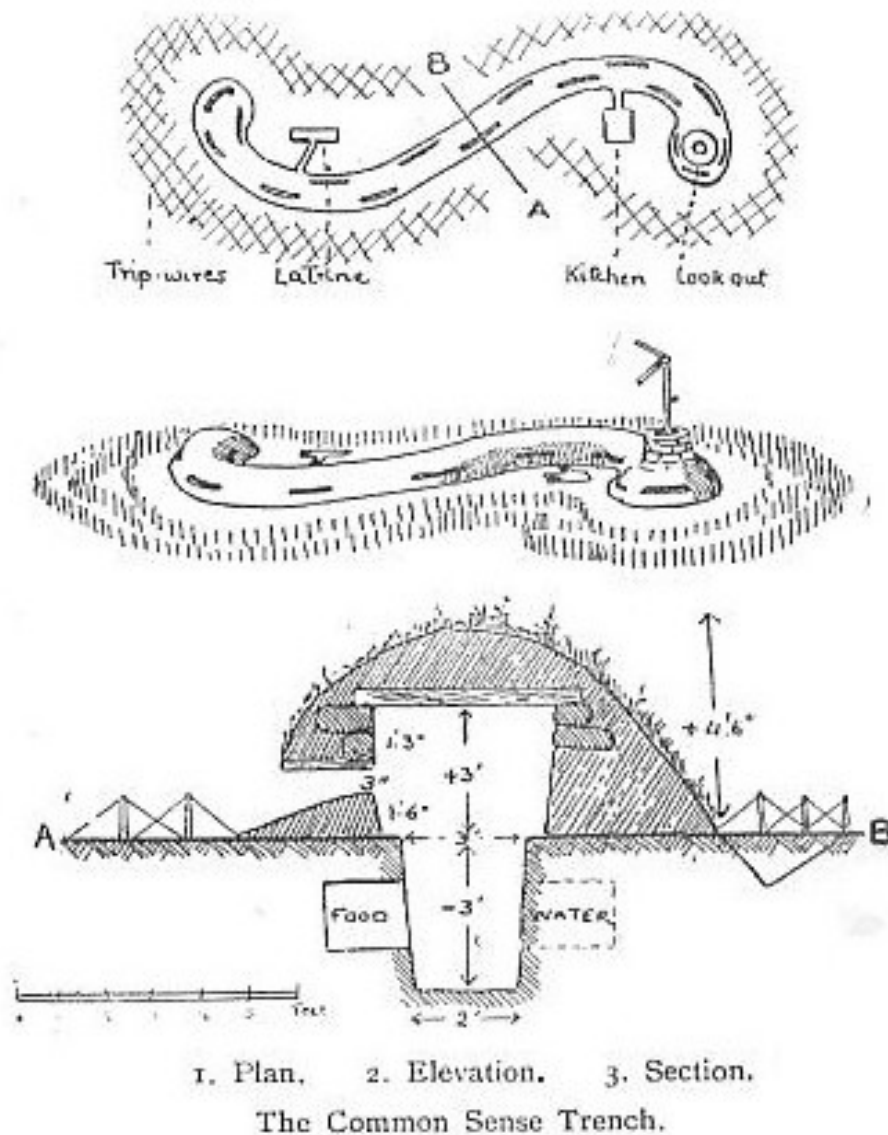
If cavalry are cunning they will feed their horses and rest themselves all the morning, and, like the well-known General in South Africa, will “put off rounding up the enemy till after luncheon.”

Why?

Because the opportunity for the cavalry comes when the enemy’s infantry have had a bellyful of marching and fighting all day and have run short of ammunition, and are weak for want of food. It may be unkind, but that is the time to go for them.

TRENCHES AND DEFENCE WORKS

Trenches and defence works come very much into modern tactics, and here again common-sense is the best director of field engineering. In South Africa we employed what were termed C.S. trenches, that is, Common Sense trenches, whose plan generally took the form of a C or an S.



These trenches again had no special front; they were prepared for attack in any direction; they were low and narrow, and thus offered no target for artillery and gave complete cover from shot, shell, and weather to their garrison. They were many times attacked during the campaign, but in no single instance were they ever taken. They were constructed in this way. Each man of the garrison had a task assigned him of six feet by three to excavate to a depth of three feet, piling up the earth on either side of him. A roof of corrugated iron covered with earth was erected over this, and long, low loopholes were made along both sides. These loopholes again were of common-sense order, that is to day, they were two feet

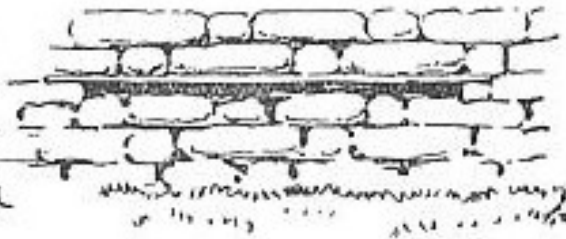
wide by two inches high instead of the usual two inches wide and four inches high. By this means the defenders had a wide range of view at no greater risk from dropping bullets, while with the ordinary loophole a man's view was very limited and his power of elevating his rifle very great: the consequence was that on more than one occasion a kind of panic seized the men holding a fort or block-house equipped with the upright loopholes. They could see nothing to fire at immediately opposite them, but hearing their right and left neighbours firing away, they were seized with an insane desire to loose off also. They did so, and at any sort of elevation that came into their mind. Ammunition was wasted by the ton, and an enterprising enemy, had he come up to demand their surrender, would probably have got it through the giving out of their ammunition.

LOOPHOLES

1. As they should be

Solid overhead

Long and low
sand bags or earth
fairly near ground



2. As they should not be

Slight over head

Narrow
story wall

High above ground
and therefore a
target for artillery



Loopholes and how to make them.

THE C. S. TRENCH

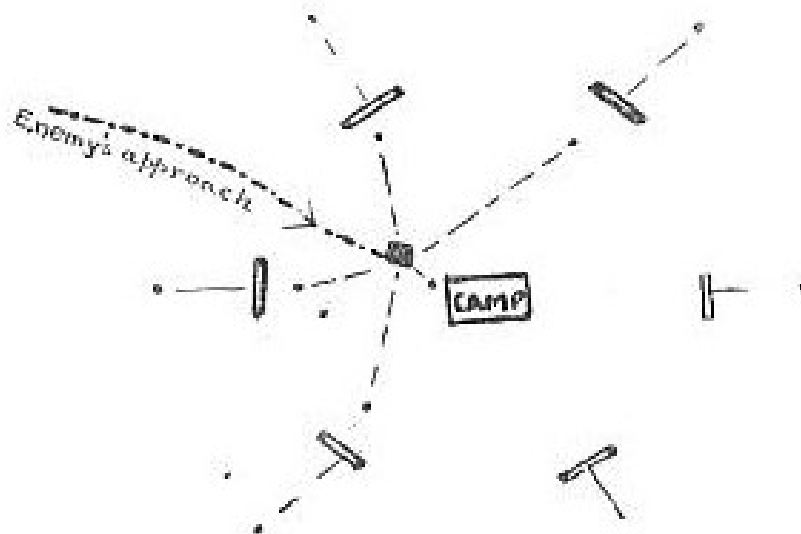
In the C.S. trenches, with their wide loopholes, the men could see out in every direction and thus had confidence. The lowness of the loophole precluded the entrance of bullets fired at long range, and prevented the men from themselves firing with high sights. Consequently they had to carry out to the letter that maxim which has led to success in many a great defence: "Lie low and shoot straight."



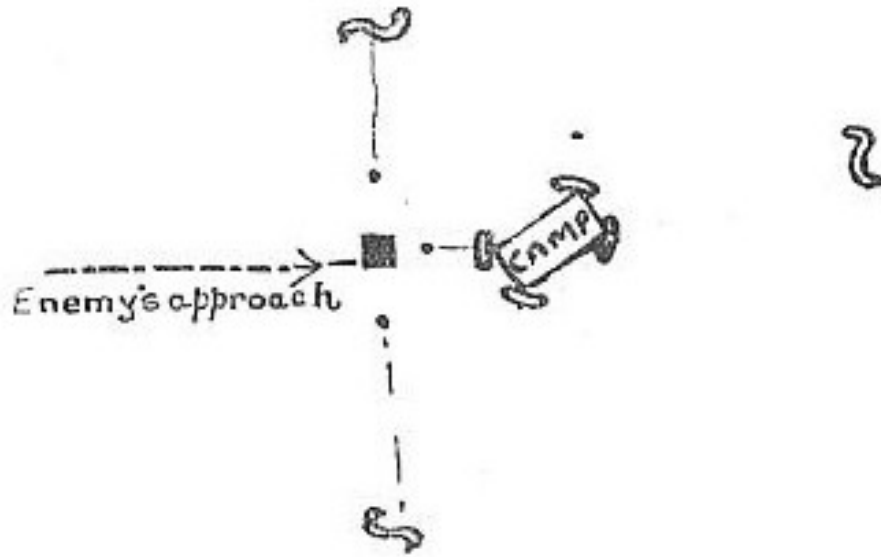
Line of trenches open to enfilade by distant artillery or rifle fire, or to be fired into from the rear.



A group of C. S. trenches free from these objections.



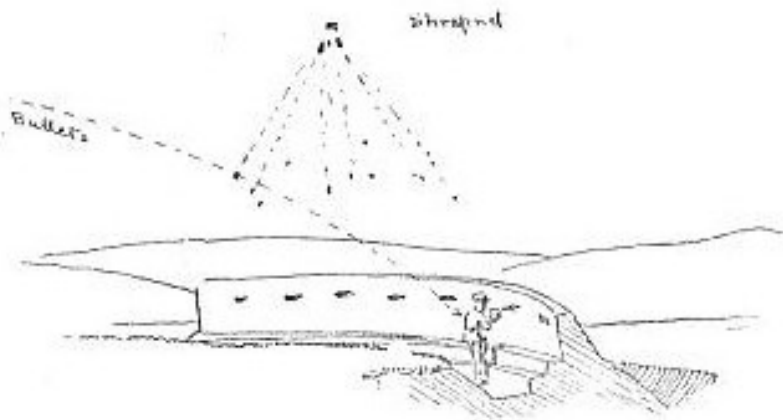
Protected camp—How not to do it. Trenches facing outwards:
The enemy enters between two and takes them all in the rear.



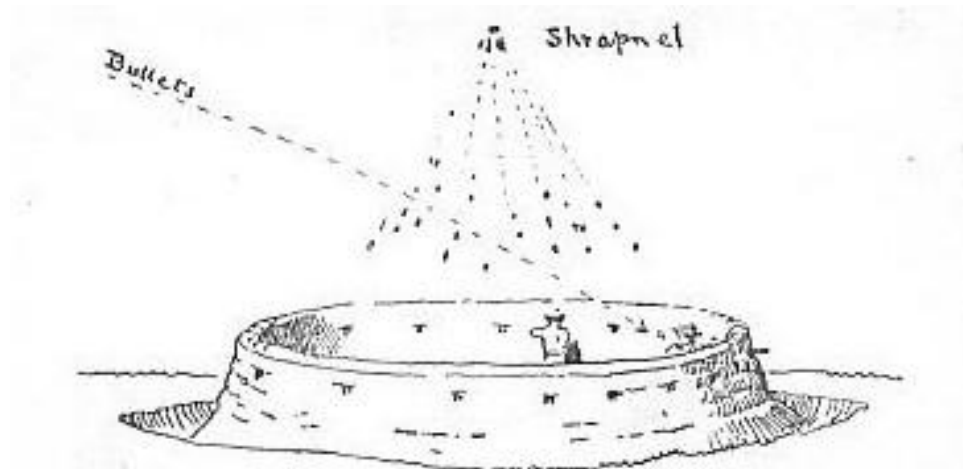
Protected camp. The common-sense way, the trenches facing all ways. The enemy enters and is under cross fire.

They did what the Belgians have recently done at Liège: they had to reserve their fire until the enemy was close up, but they then opened with deadly accuracy at the distance of a few yards with an effect that there was no withstanding, and the enemy had to beat a retreat under the full force of their musketry. These loopholes had a further advantage of giving room for more than one man to fire from them when heavy fire was required at any one point; and also, being placed close to the ground level, they were almost as deadly at night as they were in the day, since they gave the firers no chance of aiming over the attackers' heads.

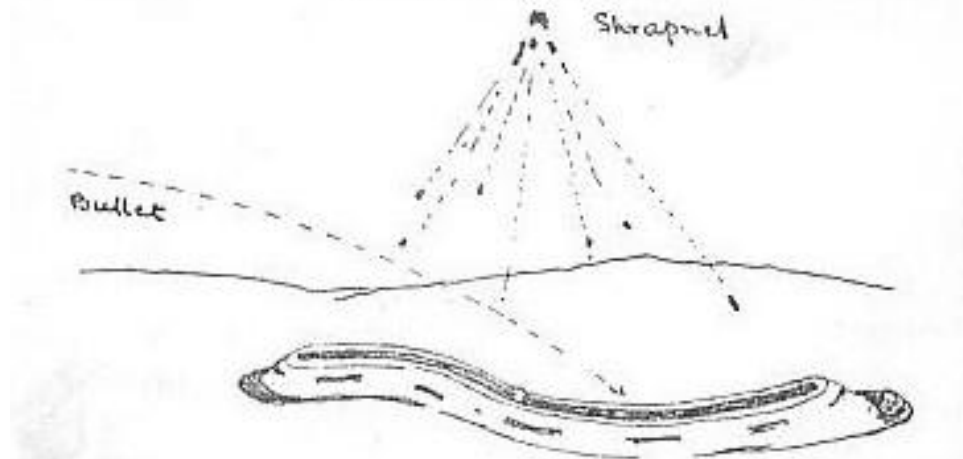
The following sketches show the effect of shrapnel, bullets, and aeroplane bombs upon defensive works, and illustrate the advantage of even an unfinished C.S. trench.



A very usual work, but open to aeroplane bombs, shrapnel, and bullets in reverse.



A very usual work also open to aeroplane bombs, shrapnel, and bullets in reverse.



A C. S. trench in a half-completed state, but comparatively safe.

SAND-BAG DEFENCES

Another common-sense way of making a work or shelter where the nature of the soil or other reasons prevent digging is with sand-bags, and I have seen it done with surprising effect by the Boers in South Africa. The site for a work may be decided upon during daylight where the ground is too much exposed to view or fire to be immediately occupied, but under the cover of darkness a party of men equipped with a dozen sand-bags apiece and a small spade or trowel can go to a spot, and with a few minutes of work can build up a sufficiently strong earth-work to protect them at all events from rifle-fire. Lodgements can be made in this way even in carrying out the attack on a force in position.

To be able to rush from point to point, taking advantage of cover and losing few men, and then being able to entrench themselves in such works as these, is of more value than being able to march in well-ordered columns to be mowed down in attacking a position; and yet the training for able-bodied men with reasonable intelligence would take far less time than the drill required for the manœuvring. A little training in pick and shovel work and in pioneering is easily acquired; it interests the men and may be of first importance on service.

QUICK TRAINING FOR WAR

COMMON-SENSE DODGINESS

What immense labour is involved in digging communication trenches between outlying works in a defence! When we had worn out our backs and tools in making these at Mafeking we found we could get just as effective cover from view by running up a few strips of canvas on stakes, behind which the men could pass to and fro unseen by the enemy — except when the sun set behind them, when they made a shadow-pantomime upon the screen!

Sentries are taught in theory to march up and down their post and to challenge all comers in a loud, clear voice. But in practice common-sense tells them that this is about the last way they should carry out their duty on service. There their system, instead of giving away their position to a watchful scout, is to lie low near the probably path of anyone approaching, and to whisper a hoarse, “Hands up!” in his ear, while “persuading” him with the point of a bayonet in his stomach!

The very best book from which to teach minor tactics in the defence of a post is *The Defence of Duffer’s Drift*. You can read it to your men and they will be delighted and interested in its amusing series of very practical lessons in war.

BRIDGING RIVERS

Common-sense teaches one that there are many ways of bridging rivers besides those laid down in hand-books, and that in countries intersected by water-cuts and canals with boggy bottoms it is essential that the men should be able to make their own means of passing such obstacles without waiting for professional engineers to come along and take measurements and work out plans and estimates before putting up an erection to carry them over.

COMFORT IN CAMP

In camp the men should by practice have become experts in making themselves comfortable and therefore the more healthy under small but waterproof shelters formed from materials to be found on the spot; and every man would be the happier and better if he could cook his own little meal when and where it suited him instead of having to go fasting for hours until the battalion cooks had got all their paraphernalia in order in the orthodox manner. The old soldier who carries his “billy” filled with the scraps from the last meal and merely has to heat it up on a little fire at a convenient halt is the envy of all his comrades, and is the healthiest and cheeriest among them.

GIVING ORDERS CLEARLY

In the matter of giving orders a depth of importance lies in their being given concisely and with the utmost clearness. If the men really understand their instructions they can carry them out with all the greater effectiveness, and if the officer can only remember to give the reasons for his order, as well as the bald orders themselves, they will be carried out with far greater spirit and energy because the men understand and are in his confidence.

CONCEALMENT

Concealment of the presence of troops is often of the greatest value in war, and is easier than may be imagined if every man is trained for the job. Hostile scout, or aeroplanes, may suddenly appear and have a look over your position, and even a large force, dressed as we are in khaki, can often escape detection if it observes the common rules for hiding. These are given in *Aids to Scouting*, and generally consist in choice of background to suit the colour of your clothes, “freezing,” i.e., standing still as a statue until the

observer has passed, dulling or shadowing all bright accoutrements, rifle-barrels, etc., likely to catch the eye. This is a matter of practice. From an aeroplane it is very difficult to distinguish large bodies of troops on roads, provided that the roads are damp and not sending up clouds of dust, and provided that the march discipline of the troops is good — that is, that they are in well closed up bodies and keeping well together along one side of the road, so as to look like a brown path alongside the white road.

HOW TO INCULCATE COMMON-SENSE

As a step to inculcating common-sense I should give definite responsibility to every N.C.O. down to the corporal in charge of a squad: let him have that squad as his permanent unit for whose smartness and efficiency he alone is answerable; and let him have all the praise or the blame according to the standard that it attains.

With emulation between the several squads the standard of the whole rises by leaps and bounds.

When commanding the constabulary in South Africa I was given the duty of escorting Joseph Chamberlin on his tour through the country. At one point of our journey we saw a solitary trooper of the force riding across the veldt. Mr. Chamberlin asked me what would be this man's duty. I replied that as a rule police patrols went about their districts in pairs; when a man was not sufficiently intelligent or self-reliant he was sent alone on long journeys in order to cultivate and develop his common-sense and self-reliance. On signalling the man to us on this occasion a few questions showed that he was going through such form of self-education.

Develop the intelligence of the individuals and the whole unit will be efficient.

Deduction of the meaning of small signs is a step towards developing common-sense, and this has to start with practice in observation and noticing such signs before putting them together to find their meaning.

A very effective step to this end, since its interest grows upon the pupils, is the art of tracking and reading signs, the details of which I have gone into more fully in *Aids to Scouting*.

Then night scouting and night outposts, night attacks and night field-firing, develop the faculties far more quickly than the same practices carried out by day, and are of real practical value for efficiency on service.

I once had to ride some thirty miles with despatches through an enemy's country. I did it in the night, guiding myself by the stars, and on arriving where I thought the Headquarter Camp ought to be I failed to find it. I was beginning to think that I should have to wait for dawn to discover it, when I noticed what appeared to be the gleam of a distant camp-fire. I walked eagerly towards it, when I suddenly bumped into a sentry smoking his pipe. It was the glare of this which had deceived me, but it had guided me. I was too grateful to run the man in for his want of common-sense in thus giving away his position to a watchful enemy.

IV

THE FOUR C'S OF SOLDIERING

3. CUNNING

IMAGINATION is an invaluable factor in conducting warfare. The commander has naturally to picture to himself the many situations that might arise, and to decide how he would deal with them. He is in this way prepared for all emergencies, but he has to go further and imagine to himself the ideas that are guiding his enemy, and then to find a plan with which to outwit him. This was one of the secrets of Napoleon's success. When his intelligence officers had attained for him the disposition of the enemy, knowing to a T the character of the opposing general, he would figure out for himself what his plan of action was going to be. He would then formulate a plan of his own for counteracting it, and, in the event of this not being entirely practicable, he would make a second alternative plan; either of these plans might be practicable on account of their conformation with the accepted tactical or strategical principles. Then Napoleon would bring his imagination into play and devise yet a third scheme — such as would not probably have been foreseen by his opponent; and this was the one which preferably he would play upon him.

WHERE CUNNING SCORES

That is where cunning comes in. For quick training in cunning, the best school is that of Scouting. The first steps in making a good scout are to teach him Observation and Deduction, noticing every detail about the enemy, and deducing a finding from the points observed. Then by a little imagination the enemy's movements or intentions are read, and counteracting steps can be taken with every advantage.

One could easily write a complete book — and it has indeed already been done — on cunning in war;* and though many of the ideas may be classed as playing the fool, there is no doubt that certain armies of leaders suffer from a lack of imagination which is almost fatal to successful work. A little example which occurred at manœuvres will suffice to explain my meaning.

An officer in charge of a cavalry squadron reconnoitring the enemy observed a horse battery in action behind the crest of a high steep bank, while its cavalry escort stood some distance away to a flank keeping guard over it. He saw that if he could approach from the unprotected flank and get close under the front of the battery, screened by the bank he could probably rush it. This manœuvre he carried out with complete success. On comparing notes at the subsequent pow-wow the officer who had been guarding the battery said that he had been misled by the dryness of the country into thinking that the dust of hostile cavalry would give him ample warning of their coming. The next day this battery was again in action, with its cavalry commander evidently again on the look-out for dust. So the attacking leader readily obliged him by sending off three or four men down a lane to his immediate left towing behind them large branches of trees, which raised a splendid cloud of dust as they went along. Away went the guarding commander on their trail, and charging into the dust found himself a captor of a number of branches and three or four men, while in the meantime the main body of his opponent's cavalry had walked into his battery and again captured it.

*See Col. Malleeson's *Rules and Stratagems of War*.

OUT-BOERING THE BOER

At Mafeking, by constantly studying with our glasses, we ascertained that the enemy's works were surrounded by wire entanglements. On Sundays there was no firing between the forts, and the garrisons accordingly came outside to stretch their legs. We knew that the wire entanglements were there from seeing how the men stepped over some of the wires and crawled under others. We therefore put up wire entanglements round our works in order to discourage the enemy from attacking them. But we anticipated science by making our entanglements "wireless," for we had not sufficient material in the place to make them of real wire. We planted upright stakes in great numbers and the men were instructed when coming out of or entering a fort to do a good deal of stepping high and crawling low for the information of enemies who might be watching through their glasses. Their newspaper accounts of the siege enlarged upon the impossibility of taking our works owing to entanglements.

MASTERS OF CUNNING

It is perhaps difficult to say where common-sense ends and cunning begins, but both are required for successful tactics. The Boers were remarkably clever in hiding their field guns, so that they were able to shell us for a considerable time before we could locate the position of their battery sufficiently well to reply to it positively. Thus they did not carry out the usual rule given in our book of instructions, viz., of clearing the front of their position of all bush, etc., but preferred to keep the natural plants standing in front of them, so long as they got a sufficient aperture for aligning their sights on their object. With smokeless powder, and with the flash of the guns thus screened, our only way of locating them was to notice where the dust caused by the shock of the discharge rose in the air; but this the Boers got over in a way which might be attributed either to common-sense or cunning: they used to carry ox-hides tolled up their limbers, and these they spread on the ground beneath the muzzles of the guns before firing, and thus prevented the dust being kicked up.

The Boers also made it a practice of selecting sites for their guns or forward trenches to put them in most unexpected positions. Thus in attacking a stark looking hill which you would expect to find crowned with trenches and with artillery concealed over the crest, you probably discovered after much waste of ammunition that the defenders were entrenched at the foot of the hill with their guns half-way up it, and generally with some clever line of retreat in a fold or ravine through which they could withdraw unseen.

HOW TO INCULCATE CUNNING

The art of hiding, whether behind a screen or in front of a background of the right colour, is taught in scouting and is a fascinating study as well as an invaluable accomplishment for a soldier. In *Aids to Scouting* I have given a number of games and competitions which tend to develop cunning in the men.

I remember being caught out when instructing the scouts of a certain cavalry regiment. I stood on a central knoll and sent out the scouts each in a different direction to creep unseen towards me and then to watch all that I did and note it down. Meantime I should keep look-out and should set a mark against each man whom I detected watching or moving. At the end of the exercise I called them all in, examined their reports, and then deducted marks from those whom I had spotted. One man had done an excellent report, but I told him that with much regret I had seen him about five times peering at me through the bushes; he ought to have used more cunning. Then he explained that he had found a countryman near where he was hiding, so he had told him to look very cautiously and he would see me do some very funny tricks, but he must not let himself be seen or I should probably not perform. It was the decoy whom I had seen. I had no reason to blame the scout for want of cunning!

RUSES OF WAR

A scouting officer in the South African campaign saved himself from being captured by exercising his bump of cunning. He had crept out along a dry watercourse to reconnoitre a Boer fort, and he knew that when he got back to a certain bush which grew over the bank he would be pretty close up to the work and in a position to study it. He came to the bush all right and put his head up, but could see no sign of the fort to his front. He raised himself higher to have a better look, and suddenly heard a sound behind him. Glancing round he found that he had passed the bush for which he had been aiming; it stood some few feet back from the bank instead of on it, and he had gone on to a second bush. In doing so he had passed the fort. The noise that he had heard was caused by some of the Boers who had been sitting in the rear of the work and who had seen him rise up out of the ditch. They were now all alert and moving as if to capture him. In a moment he turned round as if to a crowd of men behind him in the ditch and signalled with the greatest energy to them to lie down and keep hidden, and then slid down himself, as if to join them below the bank. But as he went he had the satisfaction of seeing the Boers scuttling as hard as they could go for the shelter of the fort, only dreading lest a volley should catch them before they got there!

Another scouting officer, riding up apparently rather blindly towards a batch of the enemy, had to turn and gallop for his life. As he did so he *accidentally* dropped his map. On this was marked the route which his main body was to take that day, with some notes as to its intentions — all of it invaluable information to the enemy if it had been true; but it was not. But it took in their leaders and sent them on a wild-goose chase.

The Boers were cunning in their actions, but were of all people the most easily taken in by cunning. Don't let that be your fate.

V

THE FOUR C'S OF SOLDIERING

4. CHEERFULNESS

I HAVE said before that the spirit which possesses the men is a tremendous factor for success in war, and the presence of a few infallibly cheerful men in the ranks, and more especially among the leaders, is of a value that cannot be over-estimated in an arduous campaign or when things are going against you. Anyone who has played football, polo, or cricket, or indeed has taken part in any team work, knows well the value of a captain who can face the worst of games with a cheery smile, how it puts heart into all, and inspires them to buck up and do their best, even though things may be looking hopeless.

It is just the same in war. And it must be remembered that war is not what the picture-books would have us believe — a continuous succession of glorious battles, but it is much more like the experiences described by Emile Zola in *Le Débâcle*, viz., a dreary succession of days and weeks of hard and apparently aimless marching, dull, dreary tramping in great herds, under heavy loads, utterly fagged and weary, without excitement, without hope, one's only thoughts centred on how to get a meal; that utter weariness of body and soul which make men quite resigned to being shot. An army in this state is already half-way to defeat, were it not that its opponents are probably in much the same state. But here it is that a few cheery spirits exercise a vitalising influence and are worth the presence of hundreds of extra men to their force.

A FACTOR IN SUCCESS

I have known of more than one officer who was accepted for service, not so much on account of his military ability as for his undampable spirits, which invariably develop a brighter feeling among those around him. A commander will therefore do well to cultivate in himself and in those around him a cheery spirit of optimism and an energetic activity in carrying out all orders conveyed to him. His example will be contagious. The officer who is ready to obey orders will find his men equally active in carrying out his own. It often needs a power of self-discipline on the part of the leader not to show anxiety when anxiety would be justifiable; but to show courage and fortitude with a smiling face even in the most hopeless and depressing circumstances is a God-sent gift. As stated in *Scouting for Boys*, "If you are in the habit of taking things cheerfully you will very seldom find yourself in serious trouble, because if a difficulty or annoyance or danger seem very great, you will if you are wise force yourself to laugh at it — although I will allow it is very difficult to do at first. Still, the moment you do laugh most of the difficulty seems to disappear at once and you tackle it quite easily. Bad language and swearing are often used to cover loss of self-control. Generally a man who swears the loudest is the man most easily upset, and therefore loses his head in a difficult situation. He gets fussy and anxious and upsets everyone else. You want to be quite undisturbed under the greatest difficulties, and so when you find yourself particularly anxious or excited or angry, don't swear, but force yourself to smile and to whistle a little tune, and it will set you right in a moment."

But in advocating cheery optimism I would not have you disregard danger or underestimate your enemy. Another scout's motto which may well be digested in this connection is that which says, "See the worst, but look at the best side."

In the Boer War an officer was out reconnoitring with his troop when he came upon a couple of Boer farms with their outbuildings clustered together in a hollow among some rocks and bush. The scouts reported that a number of women and children were there, but no men. The women were quite friendly

and came out and talked to them and invited the troops to have some coffee. Being of a genial and jovial nature the captain at once accepted, the troop dismounted, and the women said they would run on to the house and get coffee ready. As soon as they had started and had got well away from the troops a sudden fire was opened on the men by a number of Boers hidden in the neighbouring rocks. For a moment the men were startled and inclined to lose their heads in a panic, when the roaring laughter of their captain was heard: he thought the trap in which they had been caught the funniest thing he had heard of for a long time, and his cheery sangfroid at such a moment at once brought back their wits, and in a very few minutes they had gone coolly to their work and had the Boers out of their hiding-place and the farm in flames.

HOW TO INCULCATE CHEERFULNESS

However sad a dog you may be you have got to cultivate a cheery spirit yourself if you want those around you to have it also. It is of the utmost importance to yourself and the country that the men should exercise a cheery optimistic feeling in carrying on their work. They must not be allowed to display anxiety or hysterics under conditions that may cause either depression or elation; but they must be taught to make the best of things and to practise a cheery spirit and a ready obedience to further orders. Good health is a great step towards cheerful endurance and alacrity in carrying out commands; so, as I have urged above, health among the men ought to be very strenuously cultivated. Therefore take every opportunity of teaching your men about personal hygiene, home and camp sanitation, and all the little dodges of making themselves comfortable and healthy in camp, with camp comforts and good cooking, etc.

“A battalion of young soldiers fresh from England joined my command, and knowing how important it was to impress upon all youngsters, not only the value of their lives to the nation, but the dangers that they would incur if they neglected to obey the instructions and orders for hygiene and sanitation, I met them on their arrival by train. I marched them straight off to the cemetery and formed three sides of a square. In brief words I told them that I had much experience of the country and had worked out a guide for their welfare and sanitation in the field. These orders would be read to them later on in the camp by their officers. Pointing to the cemetery, I said, ‘There are seven hundred and fifty of your comrades there, not fifty of whom died of wounds. You are seven hundred and eighty strong, and you will all be there unless you obey my orders. I have enlarged the cemetery for the purpose. March off to camp!’ Some years afterwards one of the officers told me what an effect my words and illustration had produced, and how in his own company of one hundred and thirty men he lost in fifteen months only one.”*

On service cheerfulness depends a good deal on physical fitness, and this means not only good health but also such points as ability to get rested by knowing your work in camp and getting it done quickly and well, and thereby getting rest; *e.g.* if you are told off to slack off the tent ropes on a wet night, you do it by digging a little hole for the foot of the pole instead of going out and loosing each separate rope; also in knowing the little dodges of campaigning that overcome what a greenhorn calls hardships, but what the old hand takes in serene comfort, even if it is only to dig the little hole for your hip-bone to rest in, which makes all the difference to your comfort when sleeping on the hard ground.

The ability to manage your feet and footgear is all-important to know: that corns come from beer as much as bad boots; changing into shoes occasionally on the march gives great relief; a wrapping or “duffle” of soft rag round the foot inside the sock prevents many a sore foot. If you have to carry a water-bottle, carry it empty — every single ounce of weight tells on you, and every sip of water makes you less fit, while swills of it give you all the internal complaints you ever heard of.

**The Flaw in our Armour*, by Major-Gen. Sir W. Knox, K.C.B. With an Introduction by Field-Marshal Earl Roberts, V.C., K.G. 1s. net.

VI

HOW TO CARRY OUR YOUR TRAINING

IT is difficult to lay down a practical method by which an officer can directly cultivate and develop the moral attributes required; but, as pointed out in the manuals, they are of paramount importance. The boys of our nation are not trained in these matters in their schools, and it is largely left to them to develop their individual character according to their surroundings and environment. The whole *raison d'être* of the Boy Scouts Movement is to develop character by direct and practical steps, and if these should be of any use as suggested to a military instructor he has only to refer to the handbook, *Scouting for Boys*, to see the game and practices by which they may be inculcated.

GENERAL SCHEME FOR TRAINING — PARADES

In the instruction of his men, the officer should bear in mind the possibilities underlying each step in the training, and should as far as possible make each parade short and sweet; that is, make every moment of it instructive and at the same time interesting to the men. As a first step he would do well before going on parade to prepare a little programme of what he proposes to do in the course of the morning, and to make his scheme as varied and interesting as possible. A certain amount of drill instruction will no doubt be necessary, but if he keeps in view the aim and object of his training, which is how to fight effectively in the field, he will find his training grow with greater rapidity and effect if he make a point of having a fight of some sort towards the end of each day's work; and this should always be done by opposing forces, no matter how small they may be.

Let nothing escape your notice. Allow men to make their mistakes, and point them out when they have made them.

HOW TO MAKE THE TRAINING PRACTICAL AND INTERESTING TO THE MEN

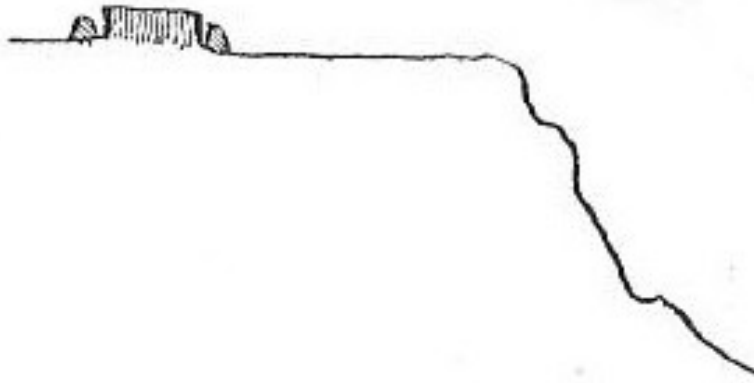
Delegate authority and responsibility to your non-commissioned officers. Make their sections and squads as far as possible into permanent units under their entire command.

Promote emulation between sections or units by pitting them against each other in competitions or combats.

Make your men take notice of details as they march to or from their field-day ground.

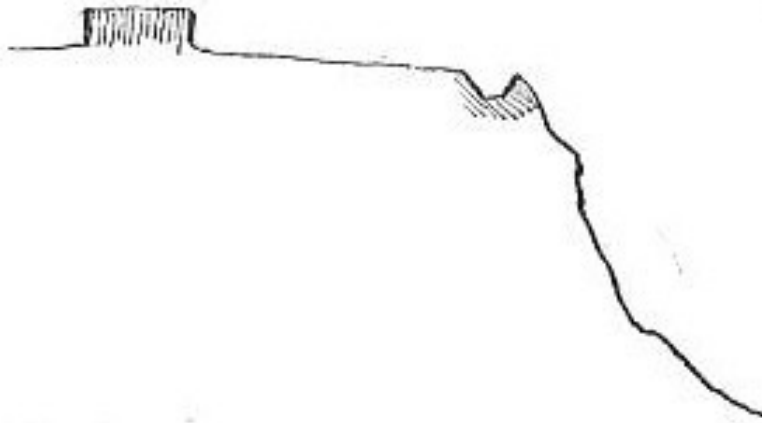
Give reasons for each point of drill, or physical exercises, so that your men will carry them out with greater interest, and therefore with better results.

Opposing forces may be placed under command of non-commissioned officers with a distinct problem to carry out. One side should wear, as a distinguishing mark, white cap-covers, or coloured rags hanging from both shoulder-straps, or bunches of leaves. One side may form a convoy of sick to get from and to certain places while the enemy are instructed to reconnoitre and attack the convoy if found. One party may be instructed to lie in ambush while the other is told to march to a certain spot and report upon it. One party may be detailed to hold a bridge-head or defile which the other can attack. One party may practise building a bridge on a model scale with broomsticks and cords, with outposts for its protection against the opposing force, which meantime had to search for and attack it before the bridge can be completed. One force could entrench itself and the other could attack when in position, using covering fire and hastily dug trenches. It is not always possible to dig earth and fill your sandbags, but a substitute, such as grass, twigs, or newspapers, etc., can be used instead. The sandbag should in any case be built up on the correct principles for cover and defence.



(1) How it was done in one case. The enemy were thus left to assemble on "dead" ground.

It is desirable to practise problems of how you would defend buildings, etc., in your neighbourhood with the materials available on the spot. It is all important on every occasion when you have made or designed a defensive work to practise an attack upon it and so ascertain its weak points. The sketches I give here illustrate how to defend a house situated fifty yards from the edge of a cliff. It is assumed that the rear face is already protected.



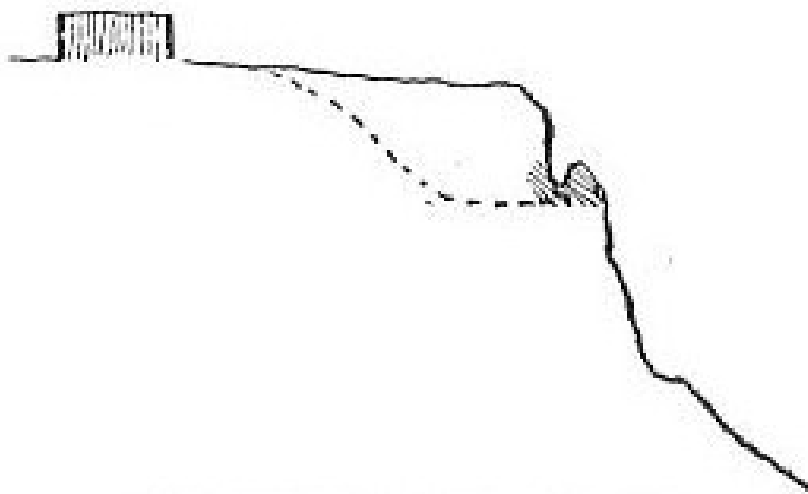
(2.) How it was done in two cases. The defenders showed up against the sky-line while the enemy were down the hollow in the darkness.

It is always useful practice at odd moments to fall out leaders and non-commissioned officers as shot in action, and to let the next senior take their places without special orders to that effect. This should be practised almost every day. The officer acts as umpire at such tactical exercises, and at the end of the action he holds a pow-wow at which, after hearing the explanations of the leaders of both sides, he delivers judgement and criticism. Where the forces are small it is all the better if all ranks, N.C.O.'s and men, attend and hear the whole story.

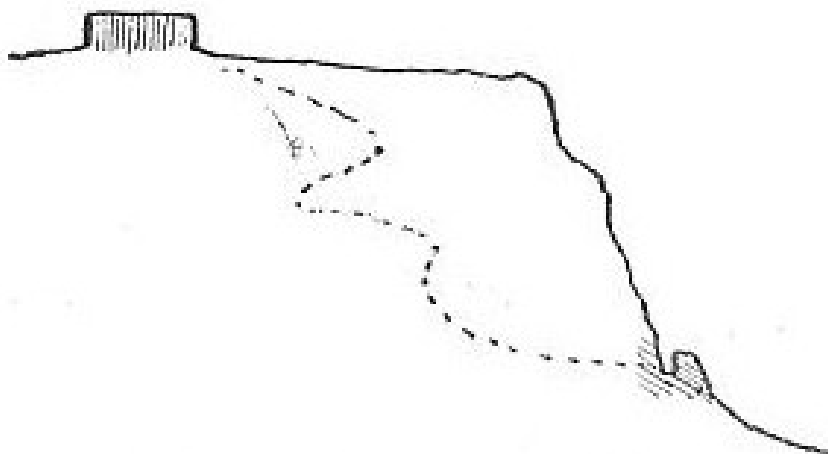
Night-work is especially valuable for outpost duty and reconnaissance, etc. It is only practice and plenty of it that makes men efficient at this kind of work, and such efficiency is invaluable on service.

Then scouting, with its branches of tracking, observing, sketching, and reporting, and the games laid down for its perfection in *Aids to Scouting*, is intensely interesting to men and offers a big programme of work. In all of these the men take an interest and at the same time see the need of the different points of

view, and pick them up almost automatically in half the time which it would take to teach them in the barrack-square.



(3.) How it might have been done.



(4.) How the Boers would have done it.

MINOR TRAINING SANDWICHED IN

The dull monotonous round of drill or the strenuous exertion of the field-day demand frequent halts and periods of rest. The doctors tell us that change of occupation is the best form of rest. Therefore these pauses, as well as the long waits on the ranges before it comes to a man's turn to fire, and the periods of inaction to which reserves and supports are condemned at field-days, should never be allowed to degenerate into waste of time. There are a thousand and one little things that soldiers want to know, and which the officers can well impart on such an occasion, by way of change of occupation. Officers here have the power of turning what would otherwise be ennui and boredom into interesting progress and instruction. They can take the opportunity, for instance, of having distance-judging competitions on the objects around them.

They can:

Practise taking cover from aeroplanes, or from enemies.

Explain the various military ranks and their badges.

Medals and their ribbons.

The duties of despatch-riders and orderlies.

Practise semaphore or other signalling.

Bayonet or sword fighting.

Explain the latest war news and its lessons, both strategical and practicable.

Explain the map and teach map-reading.

How to read the stars for finding the way.

Explain the rules of war, as regards white flags, etc.

How wounded men are dealt with in action.

Prisoners of war, how taken and guarded.

Rules regarding flags of truce, and other such matters as described in the Field Service Regulations.

On these occasions encourage the men as much as possible to ask questions, as in that way you can discover very much in which direction their ignorance lies.

Play a tactical war game.

TACTICAL WAR GAME

Once in an interval in a manœuvre-fight I wanted to explain the tactical situation to some of my officers, so taking the summer horse-sheet which my groom had thrown over my horse I spread it on the ground, and with stones and tufts of grass placed under it I made it into a rough model of the country we were working over. The sheet had a check pattern of squares of about two and a half to three inches across. These I used as quarter-mile squares. Stones of different sizes and colours represented the different bodies of troops, and opposing forces were moved from point to point on the ground with due regard to the time that it would take them to get there according to the scale.

The whole thing became so clear and so instructive that we afterwards elaborated it, and used it as an after-dinner game on a large table in the mess. A cardboard screen was slung across the centre of the table and rested with its lower edges upon it in order to hide the dispositions of the two forces from the opposing leaders until their reconnoitring parties had reached points where they would actually be able to glean information. The screen was then raised by the umpires an inch or two, so that the leaders could peer underneath it and see as much of the enemy as the hills and woods, etc., in the opponent's country would allow, until they came in full view and the screen was raised.

The game became very realistic and most instructive to everybody. I learnt many tactical ideas and dodges from it myself.

It differed from the more elaborate war games in being tactical and not strategical and very simple in its rules and equipment.

You can teach your N.C.O.'s more in an hour at this game than you could in three or four days of manœuvring, and in four or five years of barrack-square drill, and it develops their interest enormously.

THE ATTITUDE OF THE OFFICER

In Santiago, Chili, there is a splendid statue of O'Higgins, the great Irish General who led the nation in its War of Independence. I describe the statue as "splendid" because it just typifies the man. Round the pedestal are engraved four of his famous sayings. One of these gives the key to the secret of his success in commanding the enthusiastic obedience of that wild people, although a foreigner himself.

"Come on, boys, to Death or Glory!"

He was pushing troops on to the attack, and had intended to say, "Go on, boys!" but his Spanish was not quite up to the mark, and one of his staff pointed out to him that he had used the word "Come" instead of "Go." "If I said 'Come on, boys,' I mean it," and he at once dashed to the head of the troops and led the charge. But in that little incident lies a heap of meaning to every officer and N.C.O. Never ask your men to do a thing you will not do yourself. Obedience to an order will often depend on how the order is put, and disobedience or a slack performance often originates in the nagging or sharp way in which the duty has been put upon the men. "Come on, lads, here's a job for us to do," is very different from, "Here, you! just you tackle that job, will you, or I'll know the reason why."

VERBAL ORDERS

In giving order to your subordinate, tell him clearly what you want done, but not necessarily how he is to do it. He can, especially if he be at some distance, judge better how to carry it into effect according to the circumstances on the spot. Besides, it is well to give initiative, discretion, and responsibility as a step to developing efficiency.

Verbal messages as carried by excited and untrained orderlies often create a great amount of confusion and loss of time and temper; in fact, they are great fun to the onlooker. In order to avoid this among your pupils it is well to give them practice at taking a verbal message and passing it on from man to man stationed at intervals in a wide circle. To make it more hurried and realistic, it can be done in competition by arranging two circles of relays and starting the same message simultaneously round each of them, to see which gets in most in the shortest time and most correctly.

I have not here touched on any of the technical details of drill or manœuvre. These are to be found in the Military Manuals issued by authority. I have only indicated a few methods by which their teaching may be enhanced; but I firmly believe in making the training interesting to the men, so that they are encouraged to learn for themselves out of their own keenness, and the work thus becomes a form of self-*education* with them, instead of having the dry bones of *instruction* inflicted upon them.

CONCLUSION

From some experience of training recruits and young soldiers under pressure of time I know the inestimable advantage of getting the right spirit into them as a groundwork on which to build their training. Too much drill at an early stage of their career is very apt to drive out every spark of this spirit. Therefore I commend the principle of giving them work that really interests them from the very first, and especially *at* the very first, the main effort being directed to making them intelligent and active

QUICK TRAINING FOR WAR

campaigners, resourceful and self-reliant, very much as the Boers were owing to their home training and surroundings. After this train them in body and mind to their duty, and when they see better the reason for it, accurate drill and smartness can be added as a polish to the whole. Teach them from the first that they are like bricks in a wall, or players in a football team: each has to be perfect and efficient, each has to adhere patiently to the rules and to play in his place and to play the game — not for his own advancement or glorification, but simply and solely that at all costs his side may win.

THE END

IN PREPARATION

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